

Elevate Your Game, Avoid Burnout, and
Thrive with the New Science of Success.

PEAK

PERFORMANCE



Based on the book by Brad Stulberg and Steve Magness

WE ARE IN AN ALL-OUT GLOBAL WAR FOR PERFORMANCE.

The Global Talent Pool:

You aren't just competing with your neighbors; you are competing with the world.

The Rise of the Machines:

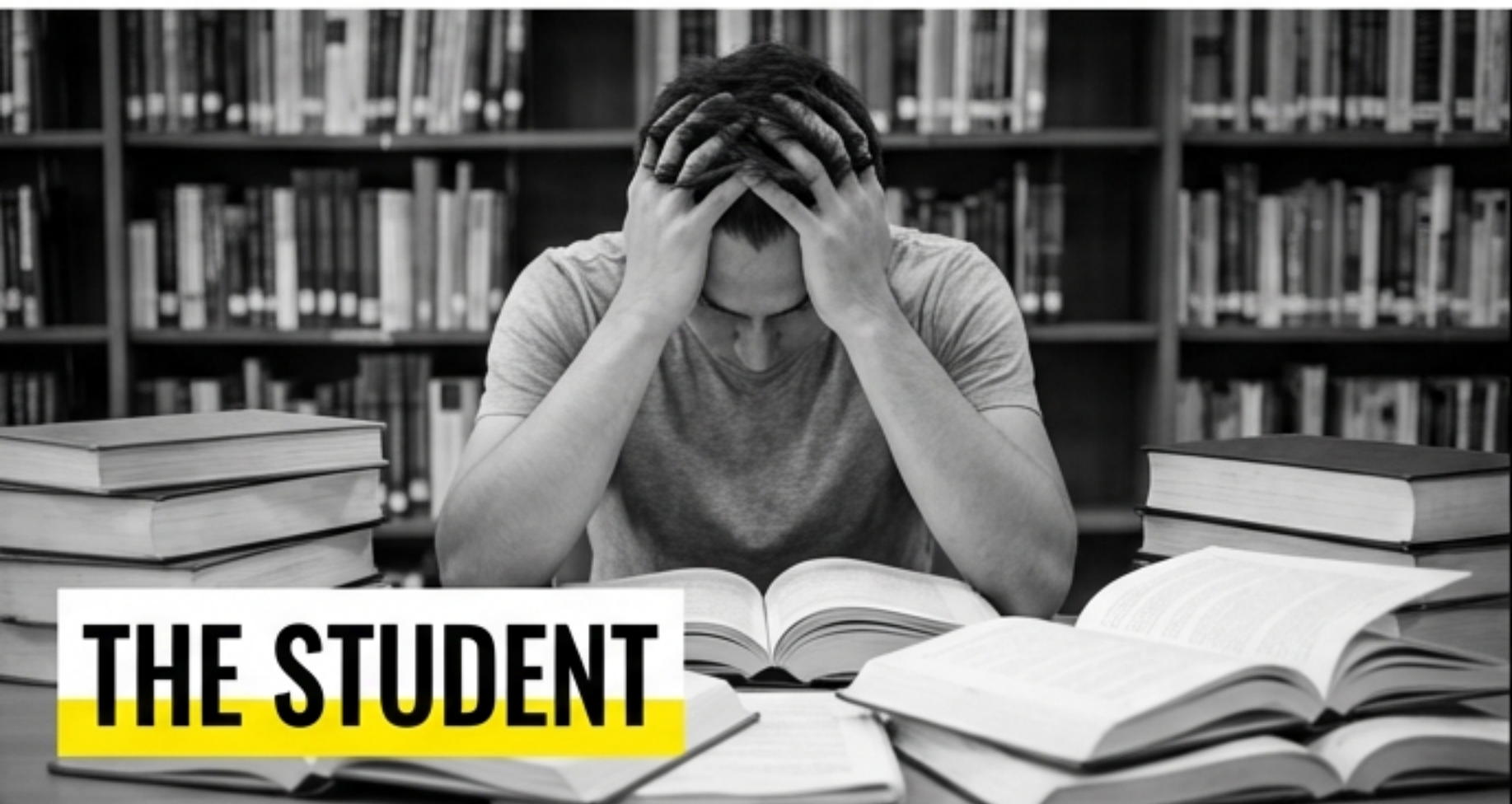
Amazon's efficiency eliminated 35,000 jobs at Borders. We are competing against a species that never tires.

The Warning: A shortage of "good jobs for good people" is driving anxiety to record highs.

400% INCREASE

Rise in antidepressant use by Americans in the past decade.

DESPERATE FOR AN EDGE, WE ARE CHEMICALLY ENGINEERING OUR FOCUS.



THE STUDENT

ADHD diagnoses doubled to 11%.

30% of students admit to using stimulants like Adderall for “academic doping”.



THE PROFESSIONAL

Usage migrating to ages 25-45.

Finance and tech workers view stimulants as “necessary for survival”.

*“Why not add drugs to energize, focus, and limit that annoying waste of time—sleep?”
— Dr. Anjan Chatterjee, Chief of Neurology, Pennsylvania Hospital*

'NUTS' IS THE NEW NORMAL.

1954



Roger Bannister runs the first sub-4-minute mile. Doctors thought he might die. It was the absolute limit of human potential.

TODAY



Over 20 Americans break the 4-minute barrier every year. High schoolers do it routinely.

The Insight: In sports and business, the bar never stops rising. We are running marathons at sprint paces.

THE BREAKING POINT: WHEN THE 'GRIND' BECOMES TOXIC

THE OVERWHELMED EMPLOYEE:

We check our phones 150 times a day.

THE 'WORKAHOLIC' STANDARD:

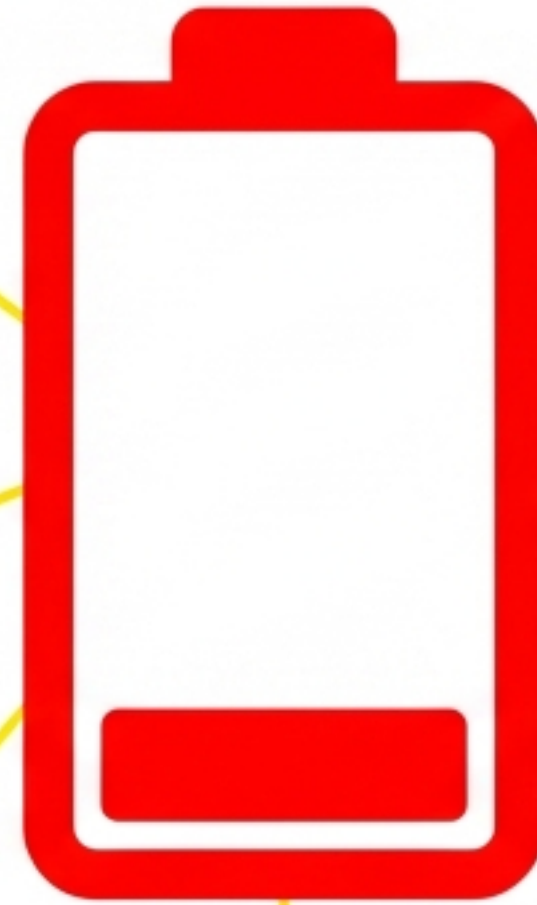
The typical American workweek is 47 hours, not 40.

THE LUNCH BREAK MYTH:

66% of American workers work through lunch.

THE TRAGEDY:

72-hour shifts can be fatal
(Case: Moritz Erhardt, Merrill Lynch)



RESULT: 53% of American workers report feeling burnt out.

A TALE OF TWO BURNOUTS.

THE RUNNER (STEVE MAGNESS)



Teenage prodigy
(4:01 mile).
Obsessive training
(100 miles during a
cruise).

Result: Performance
plateaued, health
suffered.

THE CONSULTANT (BRAD STULBERG)



McKinsey consultant
advising the White
House at 24.
70+ hour
workweeks.

Result: Anxiety and
eventual burnout.

**THE PIVOT: THEY REALIZED THEIR FAILURE WASN'T A
LACK OF EFFORT, BUT A LACK OF SUSTAINABILITY.**

THE SECRET TO SUSTAINABLE SUCCESS

STRESS + REST = GROWTH

- Too much Stress + No Rest = Burnout / Injury
- Too much Rest + No Stress = Complacency / Atrophy
- The Sweet Spot: Stress pushes the limit; Rest allows adaptation.



BIOLOGY 101: HOW MUSCLES ACTUALLY GROW.

STRESS



Lifting heavy weight challenges limits. Causes **micro-tears**.
The muscle is weaker immediately after the workout.

REST



You stop lifting. You sleep and eat. The Catabolic (breakdown) state ends.

GROWTH

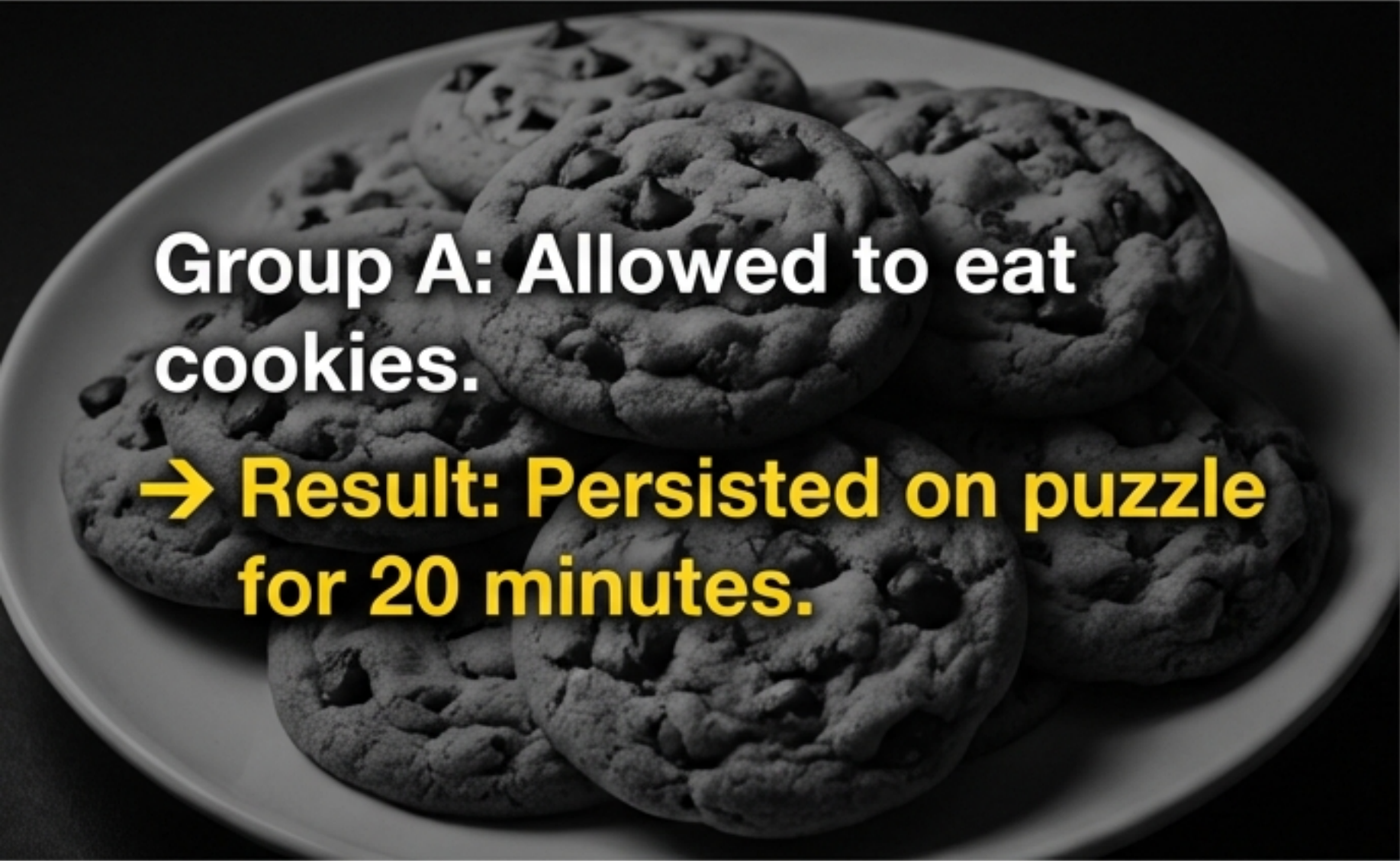


The body repairs micro-tears to be stronger than before. The Anabolic (build up) state takes over.

**[THE GROWTH DOESN'T HAPPEN DURING THE WORK.
THE GROWTH HAPPENS DURING THE REST.]**

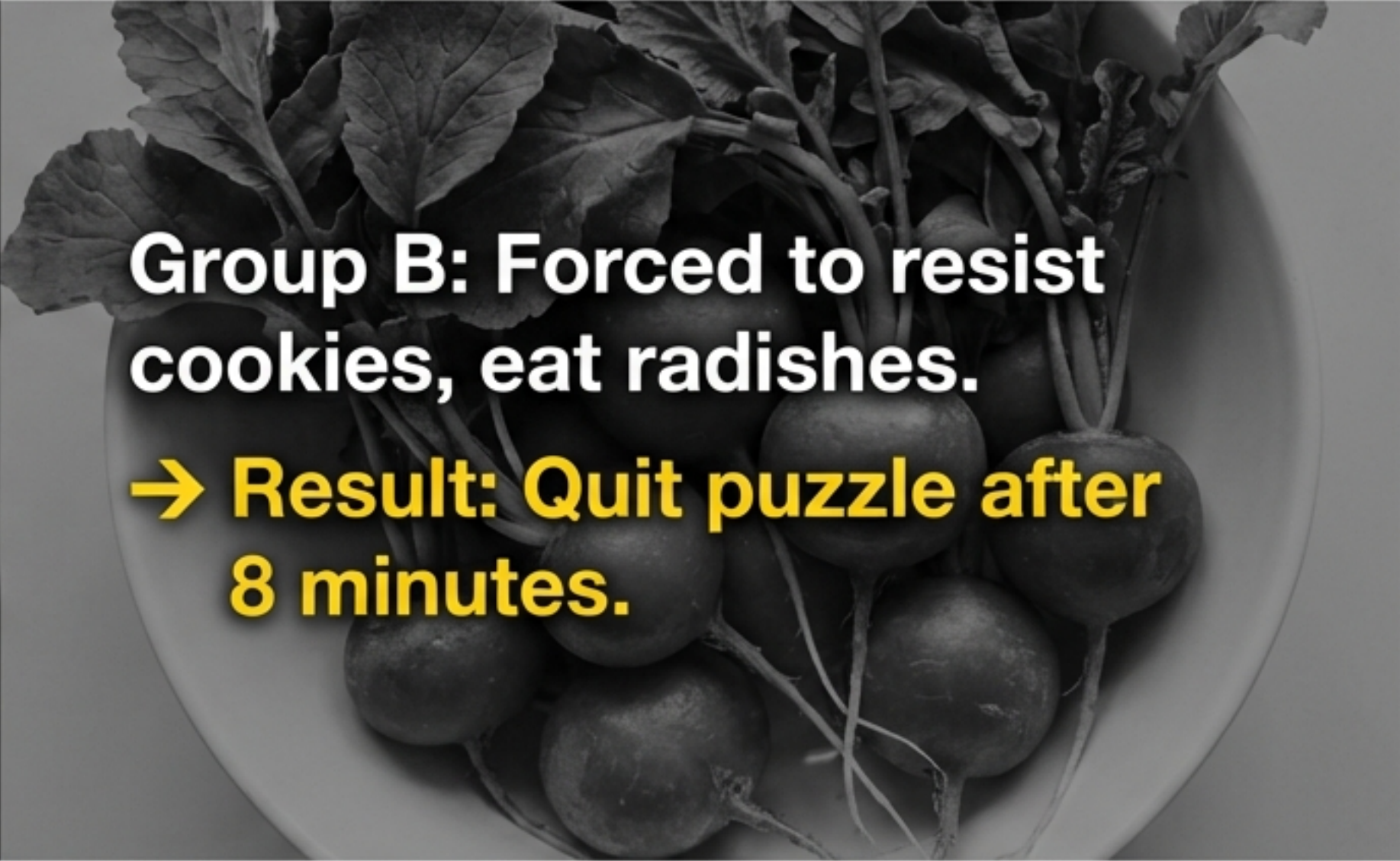
THE MIND IS A MUSCLE.

Roy Baumeister's "Radish vs. Cookie" Experiment.



Group A: Allowed to eat cookies.

→ Result: Persisted on puzzle for 20 minutes.



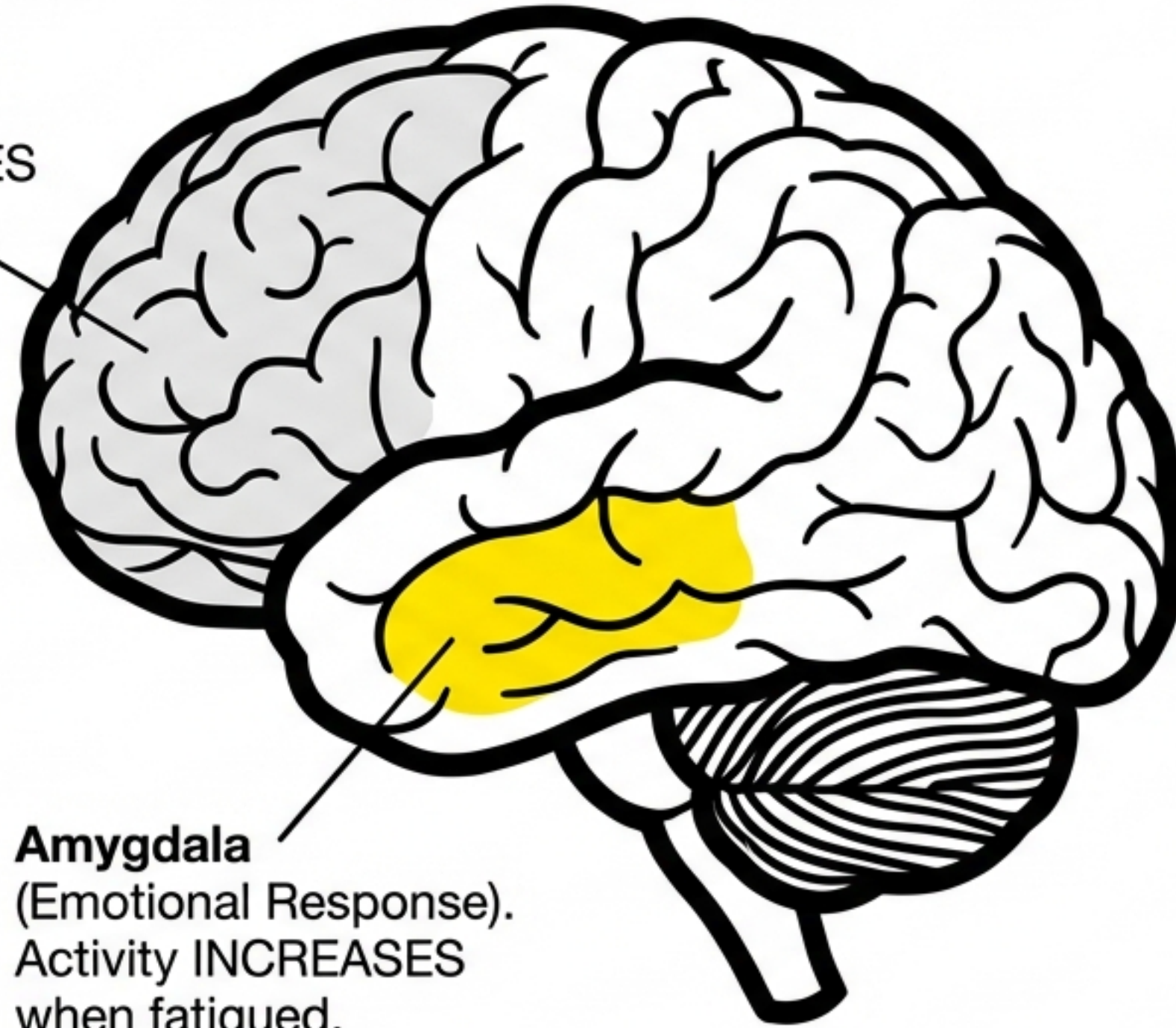
Group B: Forced to resist cookies, eat radishes.

→ Result: Quit puzzle after 8 minutes.

[Willpower is a finite resource. Resisting the cookies depleted the "mental muscle," leaving no energy for the puzzle.]

INSIDE THE FATIGUED BRAIN.

Prefrontal Cortex
(Rational Thinking).
Activity **DECREASES**
when fatigued.



Amygdala
(Emotional Response).
Activity **INCREASES**
when fatigued.

fMRI scans confirm that a tired brain physically cannot process complex problems or resist. Cognitive fatigue is biological, not just a feeling.

RETHINKING STRESS: THE TRIGGER FOR GROWTH.

Hans Selye's Discovery (1934).



Selye discovered the “General Adaptation Syndrome.” He found that rats reacted the same way to *any* trauma (cold, shock, injection). Stress signals the body: “We are not strong enough.” The body mobilizes resources to adapt and become resilient.

[You cannot grow without the stimulus of stress.]

THE DOSE MAKES THE POISON.

ACUTE STRESS (GOOD)	CHRONIC STRESS (BAD)
• Duration: Short. • Recovery: Followed by rest. • Process: Triggers Anabolic process (Repair & Growth). • Result: Adaptation.	• Duration: Unending. • Recovery: No recovery. • Process: Triggers Catabolic process (Persistent breakdown). • Result: Burnout & Inflammation.

Stimulus ●—————● **The Dose** —————● Toxic

SKILLS COME FROM STRUGGLE.



Case Study: Josh Waitzkin.

- Chess Prodigy (*Searching for Bobby Fischer*)
- Tai Chi World Champion

Growth comes at the point of resistance; we learn by pushing ourselves to the outer reaches of our abilities.

- **Method:** Push the mind to exhaustion, then cycle energy. Stress at the edge of ability.

THE PARADOX OF REST: TO GO FASTER, YOU MUST SLOW DOWN.



DEENA KASTOR'S SECRET ROUTINE

- ✓ 140 miles/week (The Work)
- ✓ 10-12 hours of sleep per night (The Secret)
- ✓ Monthly massages
- ✓ Meticulous diet

The leaps and bounds I've made... have come from outside the training environment and how I choose to recover.

WHY GOLD MEDALISTS WALK UP HILLS.

Polarized Training Model

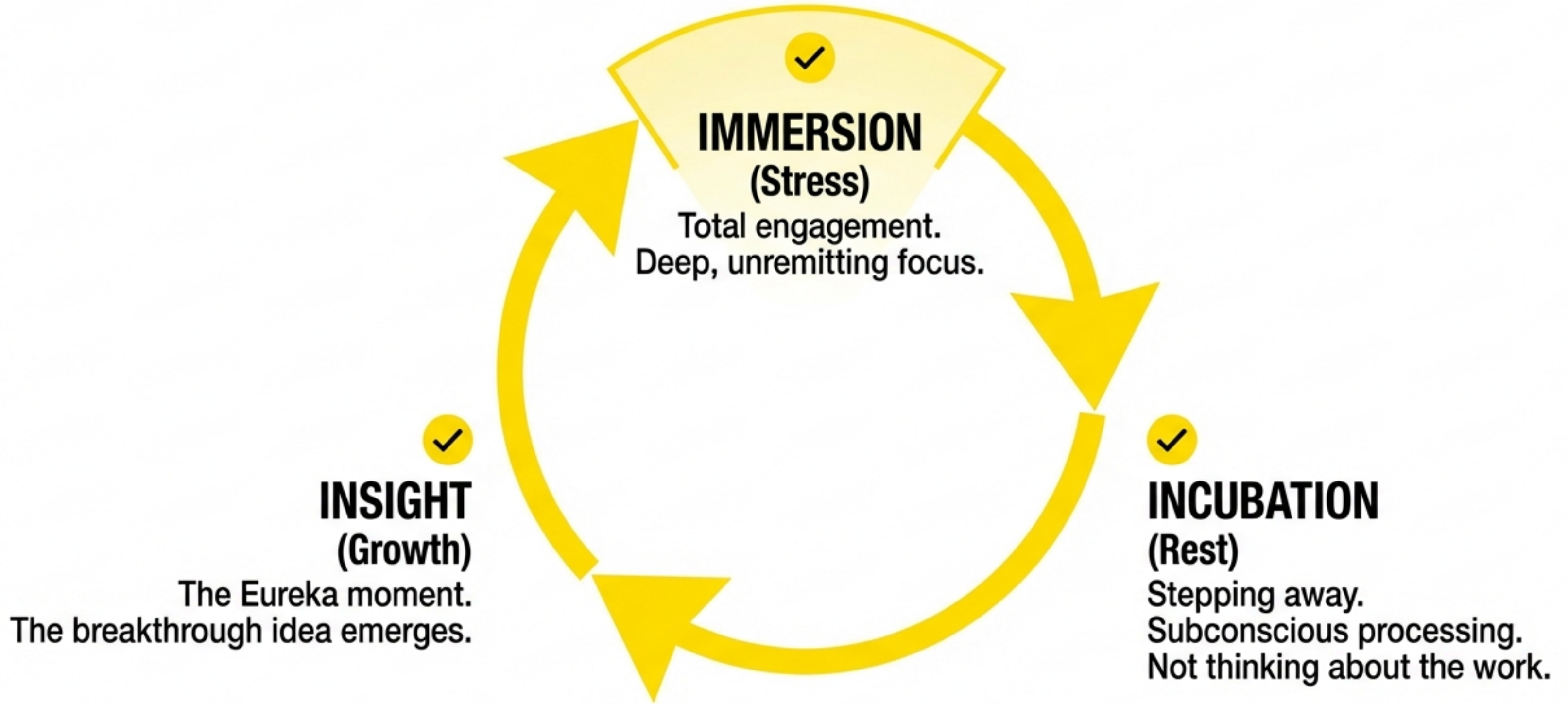


80% Low Intensity (Recovery/Maintenance)

20% High Intensity (Stress/Growth)

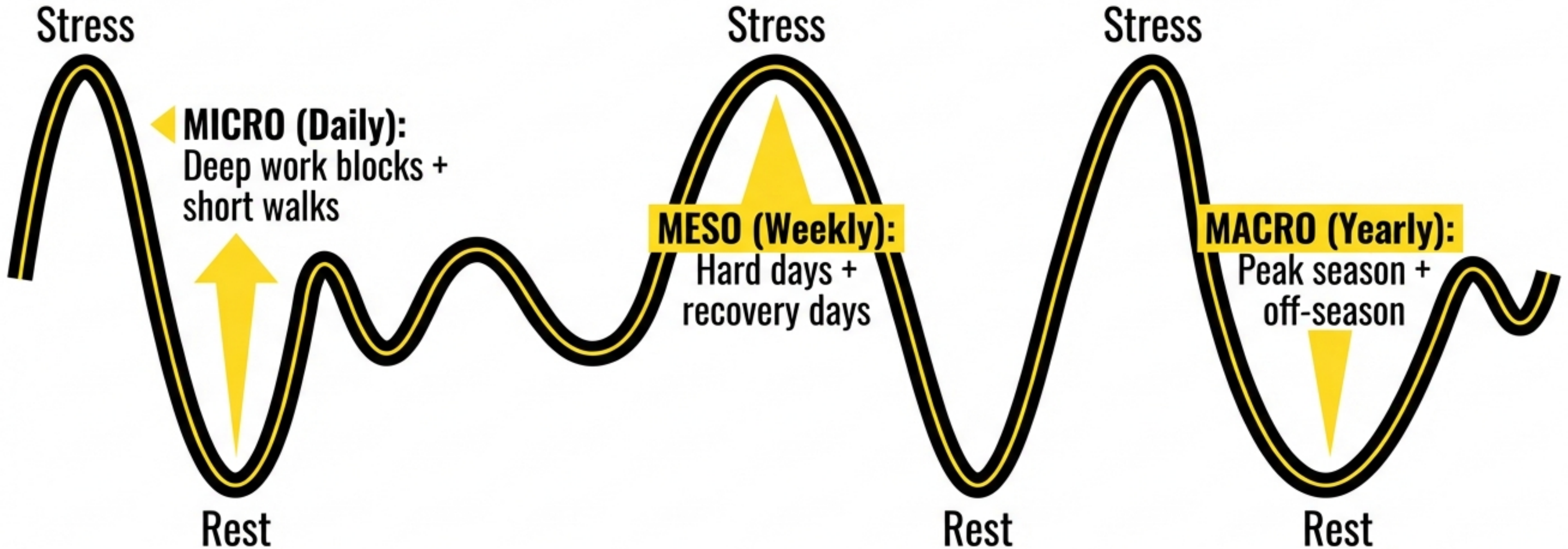
Research by Dr. Stephen Seiler on elite skiers and runners. They do not follow “No Pain, No Gain” 24/7. To adapt to yesterday’s hard training, they must train easy today.

THE CREATIVE CYCLE: HOW GENIUSES WORK



Based on Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi's study of Nobel Prize winners. You cannot have the Insight without the Incubation.

PERIODIZATION: THE RHYTHM OF EXCELLENCE



Key Takeaway: Avoid the “Grey Zone”—medium stress all the time—where you are too tired to perform, but not resting enough to recover.

PERFORMANCE PRACTICES: OPTIMIZE STRESS.



- **Find Your ‘Goldilocks’ Challenge:** Manageable struggle. Hard enough to fatigue, not hard enough to break.
- **Single-Tasking:** The brain is a muscle with limited energy. Do not multitask.
- **Isolate the Muscle:** Define exactly what capacity you want to grow and stress *that* specific capability.

PERFORMANCE PRACTICES: PRIORITIZE REST.

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- **Respect the Cycle:** High stress must be followed by recovery.
- **Sleep is Productive:** It is not a waste of time; it is when the growth happens.
- **Short Breaks Matter:** A 5-minute walk can reset the prefrontal cortex.
- **Tweak Your Environment:** Remove temptations when you are fatigued and willpower is low.

NURTURE YOUR NATURE.

**STRESS IS THE
STIMULUS.**

PEAK
PERFORMANCE



**REST IS THE
GROWTH.**

BALANCE IS THE KEY.

“The best athletes also prioritize recovery, time on the couch and in bed, just as much as they prioritize time on the track or in the gym.”